INFO - 4609

Research Deliverable for Strava Simplified

Literature Review/Competitive Analysis

From my research Strava has changed a lot since its first launch, and most of these changes have been things being added. In June of 2026, Strava added new hiking tools including route discovery, a full screen map, and live elevation data, and some more features locked behind the pay wall. There was also an earlier redesign that re-worked the home page navigation buttons. Normally when apps add features it is a good thing, but in the case of Strava, I think it has hurt it more than it has helped and that is the main reason for this project.

There have been existing critiques of this same issue. One design critique that I came across from “IXD@Pratt’, a collection of articles talking about UX/UI design of apps, said that the “You” section can be accessed from two different points on the same home view. This alone adds redundancy and even confusion to users because it blurs on what element does what, even though they both do the same thing. Another problem that came up from this same article was when you first started using the app, it would ask you many personalized questions, but the interface after did not reflect this personalization. Another UX case study found the most individuals wanted a much simpler interface, especially for quick access to essential stats, but the small phone screens made all of that more cluttered and less intuitive. There have also been complaints from Strava’s own community from talking about cluttered navigation menus that make many features hard to find. Many of these compilations line up with “interface bloat”, where everything becomes too hard to navigate because there are too many features and buttons.

There are many different competing apps that handle their UX/UI design differently. For example, Garmin Connect is very data driven and that is what its focus is. It syncs all of the Garmin device data and offers different training and recovery tracking, but that is its main purpose, unlike Strava. Another comparison that was made was between Strava and Nike Run Club. Many reviews say it is a great choice for newer runners or anyone who wants free coached workouts, but it is limited in its analytics and only tracks running. Strava does strive in one aspect and that is its social features and segments.

My take away is that Strava is the middle ground trying to serve everyone. It has a lot of dense and helpful data, like Garmin Connect, but can also be used in an easier way for people to just track their runs or workouts. From this research I hope to fix many of the complaints about the cluttered interface while still keeping what makes Strava so good with its wide range of possible uses.

Findings from Survey data

Link to Survey Questions - https://forms.gle/2m9P7nbYj8QwSmRG7

Unfortunately I did not get nearly as much data as I was hoping for my surveys but I still got enough to work with. I sent out this survey to every person that I knew that used Strava, and asked them to send it to every person they knew that used it as well. From the number of responses, it looks like the only people that responded were the people I personally sent it to. If

I were to do this again I would try and send it out in more places where Strava users would be, such as run clubs, or something though the Rec Center. I will be checking these responses over the next week to see if maybe more people just responded late or it is still getting passed around. I will keep that data in consideration for the rest of the project.

From my responses, eight people said they use Strava for casual activity tracking and eight said they used it for social posting, while only four used it for structured training. Everyone logged running, and hiking was second with seven. Most people open the app a few times a week. This makes sense since most people don't run/train every day. The most used features were basic activity tracking and the social feed, each having eight. These were followed by segments and performance tracking, each with 6. Features like the route builder and clubs were only used by one or two people, showing that those go mainly unused.

The overall satisfaction of Strava was average. The average score was 6.8. There were only responses for six and eight, so no one absolutely loved it, but no one gave it a worse score than 6. There was a gap between paid users and not paid, but with such a small sample size since there were only 3 paid users. It seems like Strava is succeeding at satisfying everyone with this mediocre score.

There was a 70/30 split between paid users and unpaid users. Of those 7 that haven't paid, three considered upgrading and four had not. The reasons for this were the cost, not needing the extra features blocked behind the pay wall, or having a watch that was able to comparably cover the same ground in data collection.

The open-ended questions had a few themes:

- **Social is what people like best.** Three respondents named seeing friends' activities and encouraging them as their favorite part.
- **Maps, routes, and data are the other highlights.** Others praised route visualization, the route builder, segments, analytics, and Apple Watch integration. One person liked that the interface changes for each activity type.
- **The paywall is the biggest complaint.** Two respondents objected to features being visible but locked, including turn-by-turn route guidance during a run and offline maps.
- **Groups and training plans go unused.** Two people avoid the groups feature, and two avoid the training plan feature, with one describing it as only suggested workout panels instead of a plan they can track.
- **The map screen can overwhelm.** One respondent said they never use the map because they get bombarded with information when they first open it.
- **Usability gaps came up too.** One respondent can't see their data from the lock screen during a workout. Another can't tap into someone's full profile from an activity. A third has mostly stopped using Strava because their watch covers everything and they dislike feeling pressure for people to react to their workouts.

Limitations

This was a small sample size of only 10 people unfortunately. It also likely skews towards college students and runners, so these results can show some patterns but definitely not conclusions. I also ran into a very large problem with someone I had set up an interview with this past weekend. We were supposed to have our interview Friday evening, but they had to cancel at the last minute. I still plan on interviewing this individual later this week, since the

information that I can get from talking one on one I think will be indispensable. I expect to be able to gain more depth about pain points in the app and be able to ask very helpful follow up questions on ways that Strava could improve.

Connection to Design

With the data that I collected there are a few main points that I will be focusing on. I will also be taking my literature review into consideration and what I learned from that in my design process. From what I found:

- Make the social feed more prevalent and maybe the center of the app, since it was the most used feature from the survey
- Move less used features like groups, training plans, or route plans out of the primary navigation, or only have them for the users that use the most
- Clearly label what is locked and what is locked behind the pay wall and don't present them as if they were
- Simplify the map feature to not be as overwhelming
- Add lock screen access or a live stat view
- Make activity post link straight to full profiles

Baseline Interview Questions

Background & habits

How did you first start using Strava, and what made you stick with it?
Walk me through what you typically do in the app during and after a workout.
Has the way you use it changed since you first started?

What works well

4. What's the first thing you check when you open the app?
5. What's one feature you'd genuinely miss if it disappeared? Why does it work so well for you?

Pain points

6. Can you think of a recent time Strava frustrated you or got in your way? Walk me through exactly what happened.
7. Is there anything you've just stopped doing in the app because it was too annoying or confusing to use?
8. Are there any features you know exist but avoid or don't fully understand?

Improvement ideas

9. If you could change one thing about Strava, what would it be and why?
10. Is there anything you wish the app did that it doesn't right now?